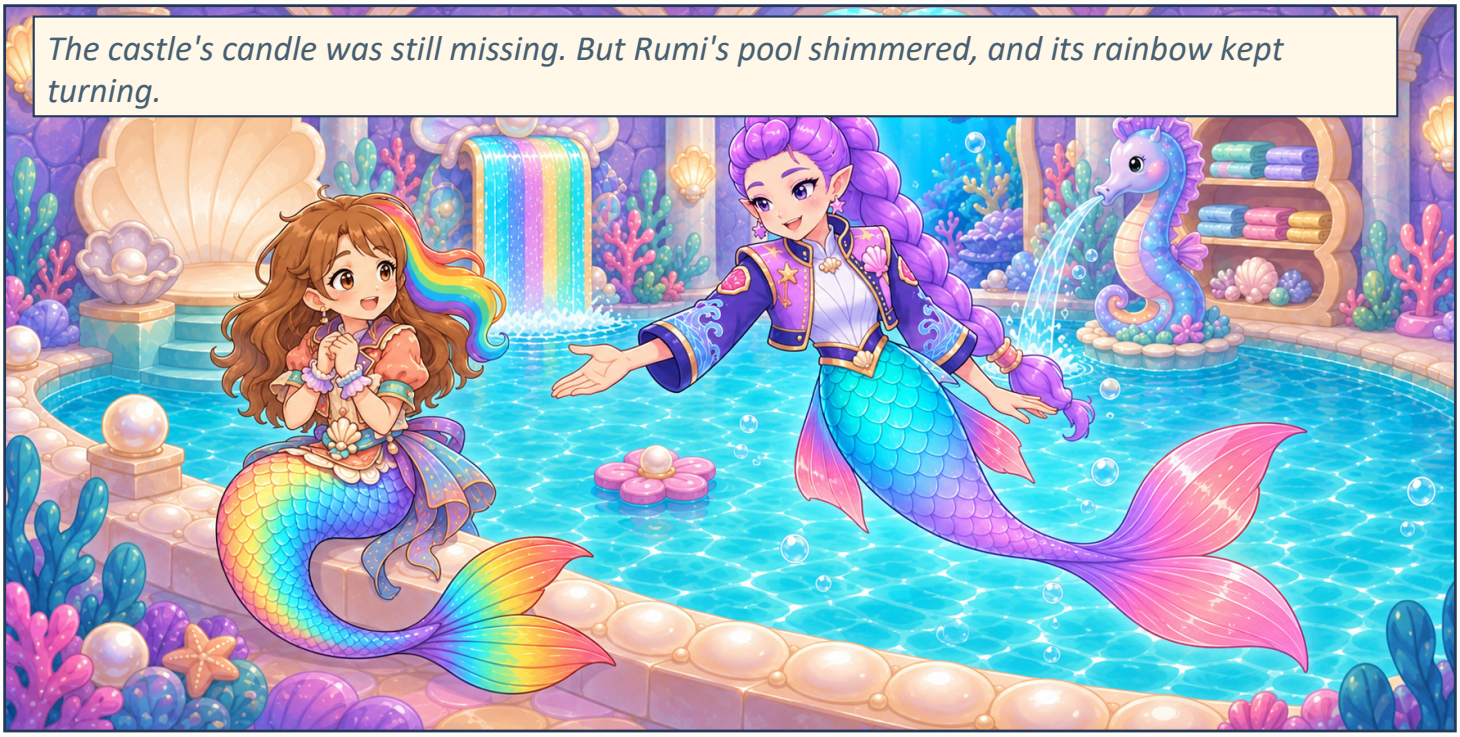
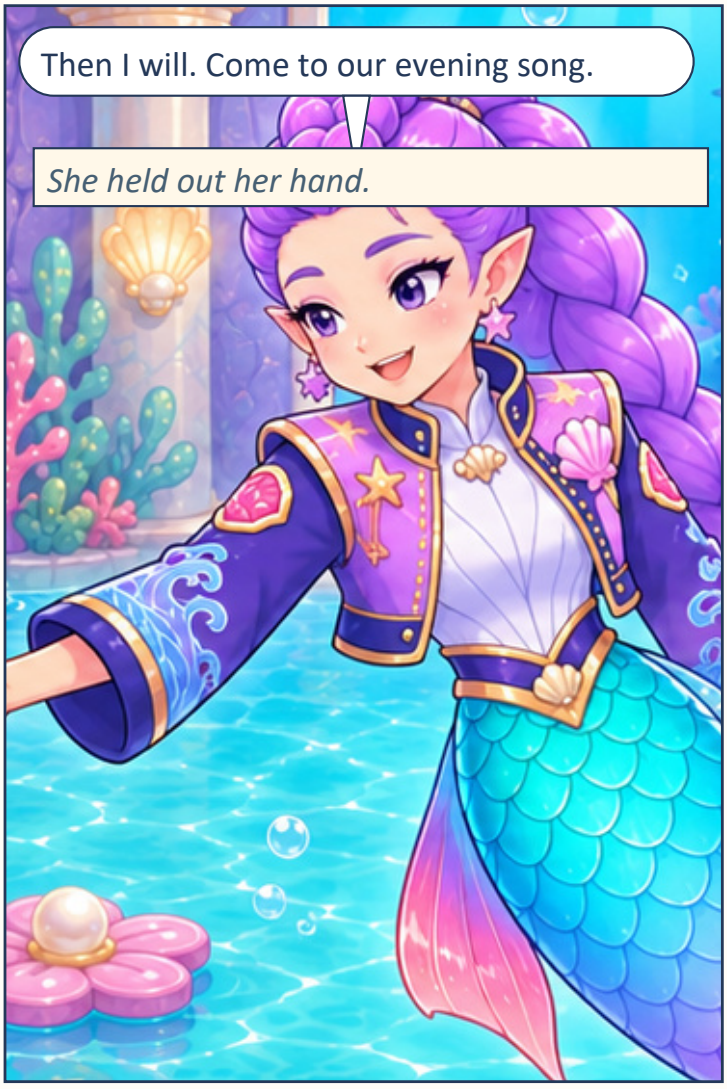
Mermaid Roshan and the Song Beneath the Pool

Rumi's undersea adventure
A little voice. A whole city listening.


The castle's candle was still missing. But Rumi's pool shimmered, and its rainbow kept turning.

What if nobody hears me?


Then I will. Come to our evening song.
She held out her hand.

Down they swam, through the shining oval beneath the pool. A whole city glowed below.

Curved roofs. Peach windows. Seaweed gardens.

Roshan: We're still in the castle?

Rumi: Every bit. Even the bubble tram!

A bubble tram glided over the pearl bridge. Roshan started after its sparkling bubbles.
Wait. Our way is underneath.
Watch that leaf. It shows where the water goes.
Roshan watched it curl around the pillar.
She slowed her tail, followed the curve and slipped through the clear arch.
The water helped me!

I'm Duri. These bells are for tonight's song. That banner goes to the stage.

One bell drifted into the kelp. Roshan followed the curling water and caught it gently.

Duri: Thank you! I'll meet you at the music room after this delivery.

His little bell went ding, ding, ding.

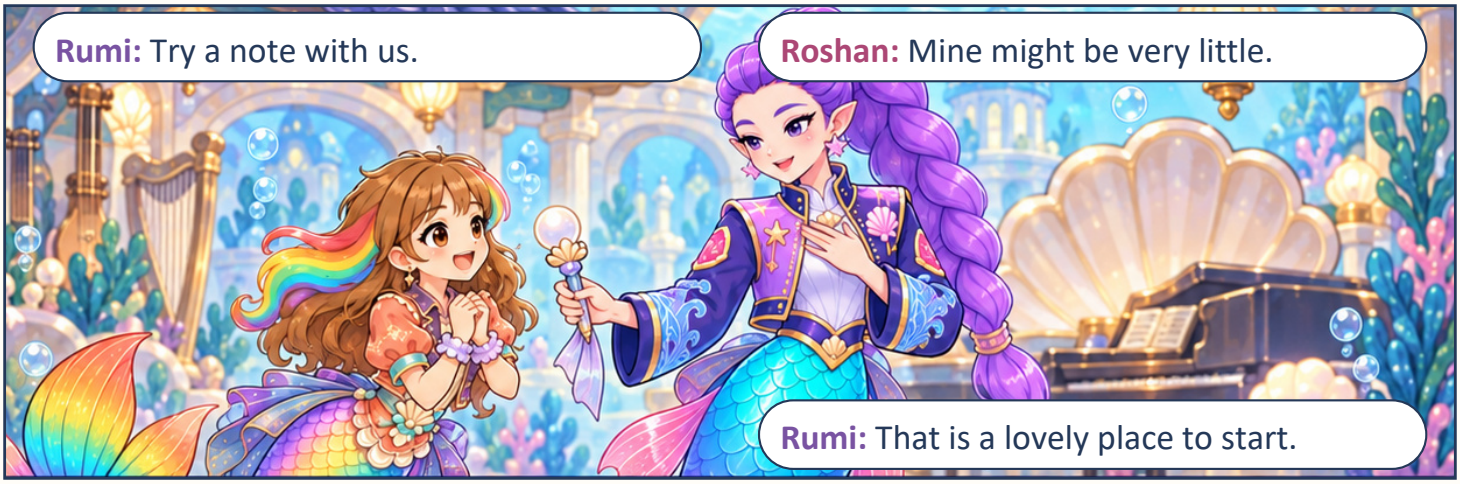
Rumi led Roshan to the music room. Two friends were waiting under its curved roof.

I'm Hana. I dance BIG!

Her copper hair floated behind her.

I'm Nari. I hear tiny things.

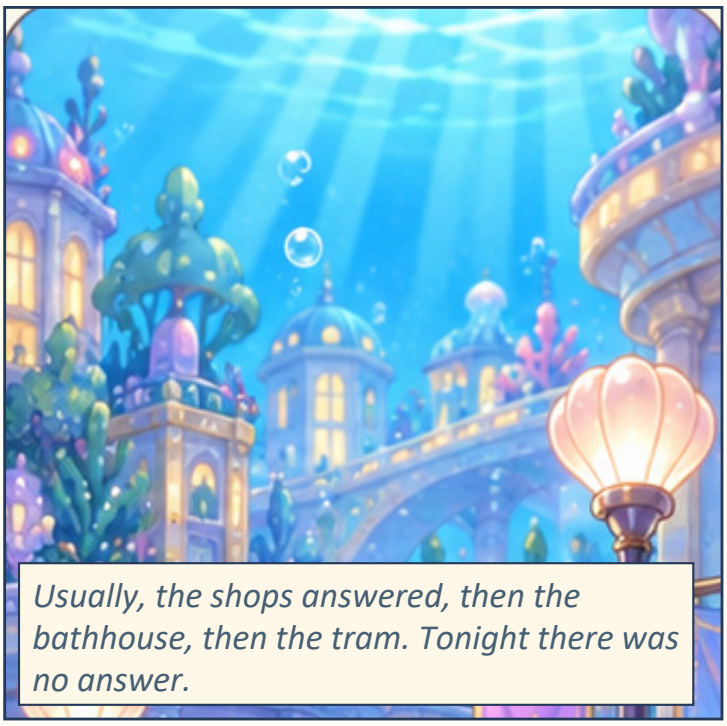
Roshan: I'm Roshan. I'm glad to be here.

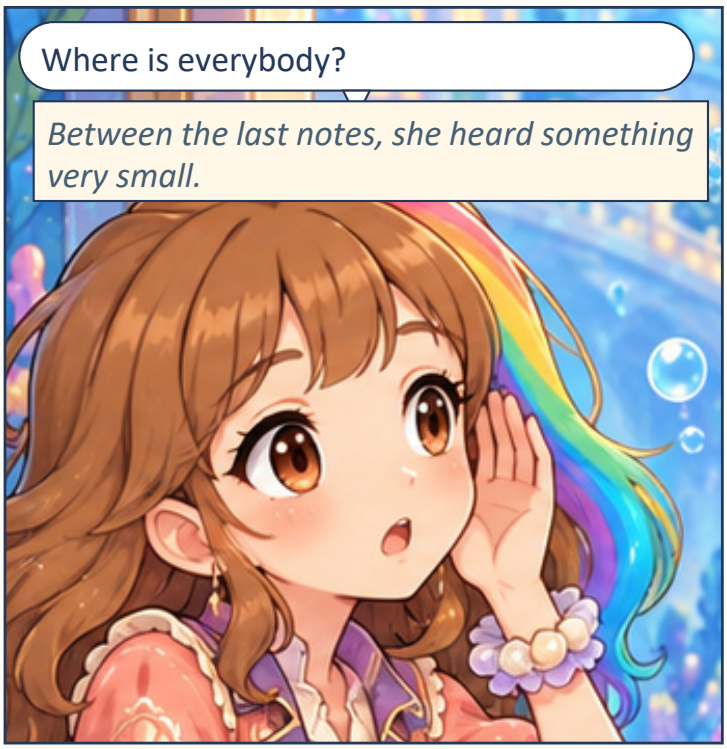


Hana spread her arms for a BIG dance. A ribbon brushed Nari's hair.

Hana made a smaller turn. Roshan copied her and tried a tiny note.

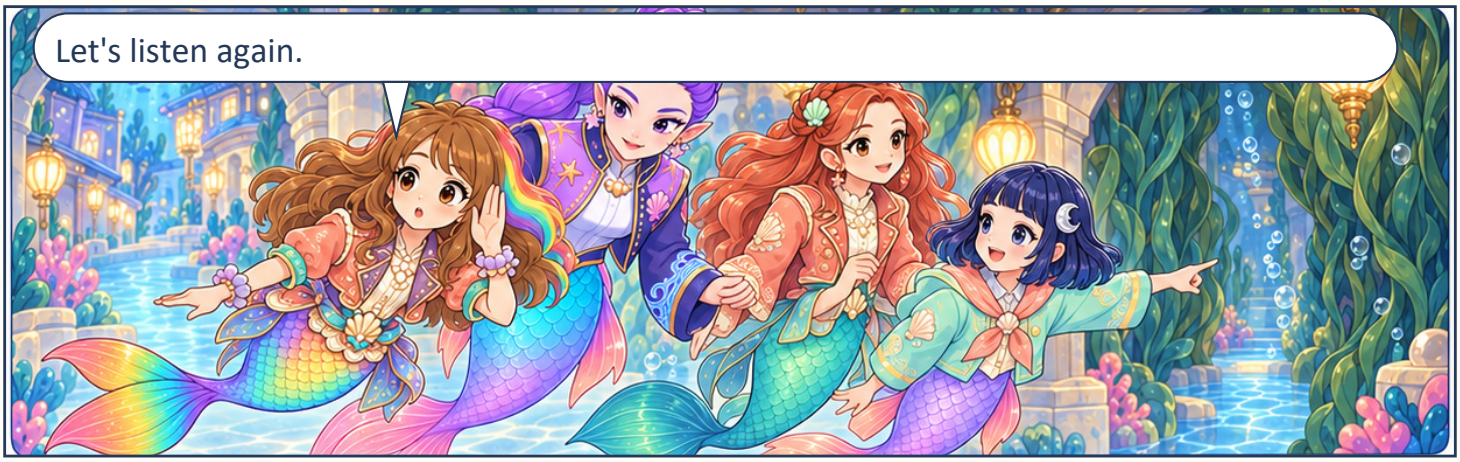
Little voice, big blue sea.
Sing with you, sing with me.


Usually, the shops answered, then the bathhouse, then the tram. Tonight there was no answer.

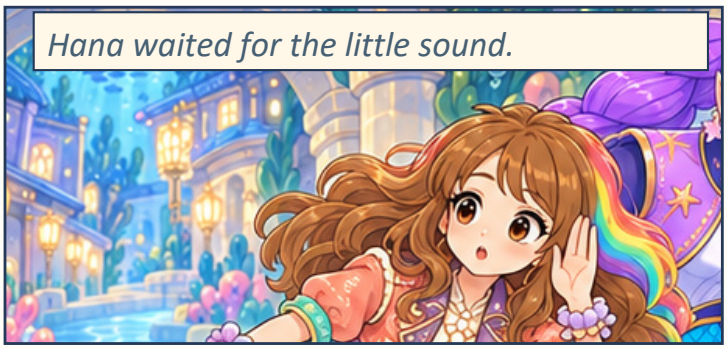

Where is everybody?
Between the last notes, she heard something very small.

Hana drew a breath to sing louder. Roshan raised one hand.
Wait.
Tap. Tap. Tap.
A bell?
No. Someone knocking. Down there.
The friends held still. This time, everyone heard it. They followed Roshan out of the music room.

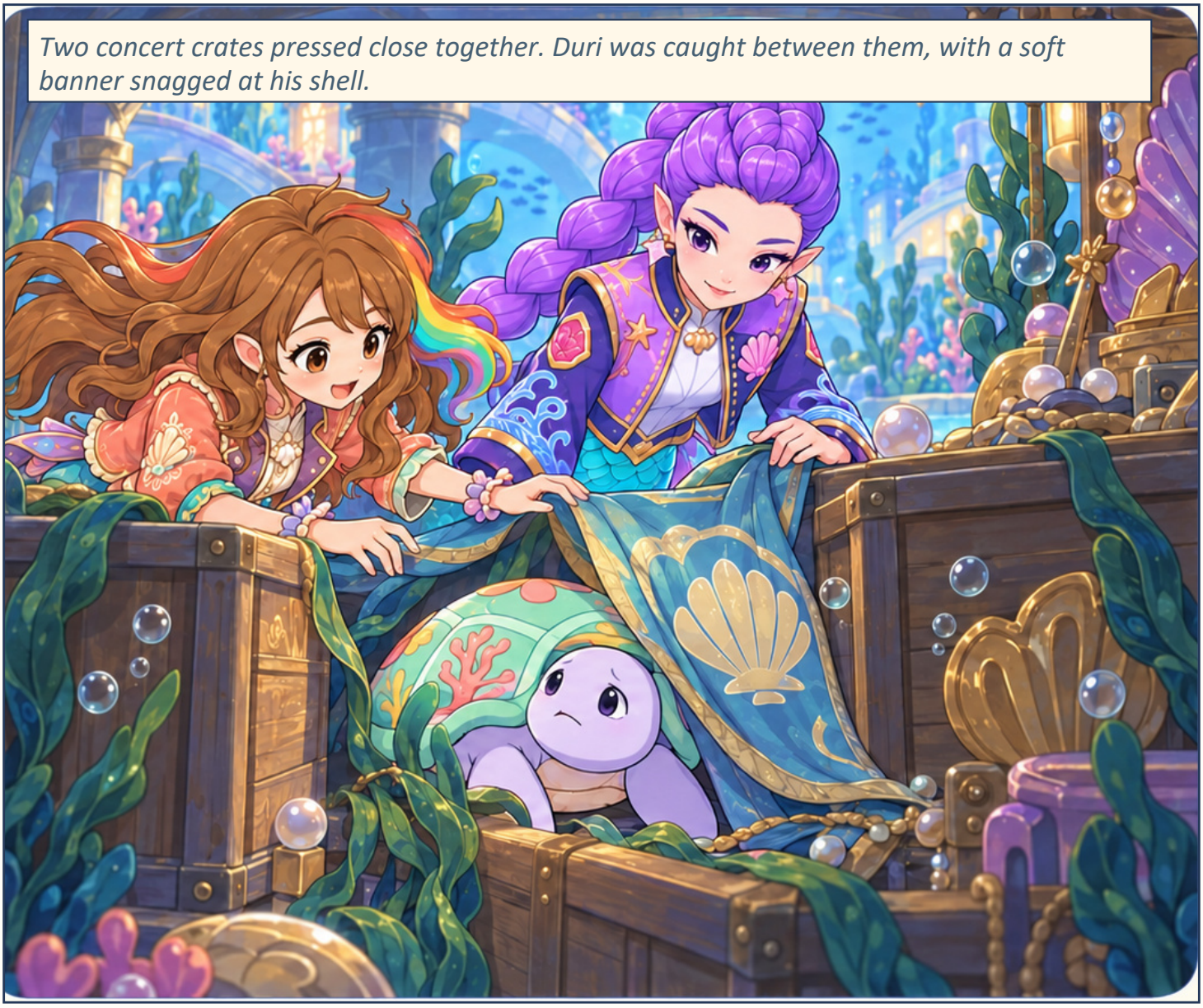
The tapping led below the tram bridge. Two arches opened beside the pillar.
Hana: Which way?


Let's listen again.

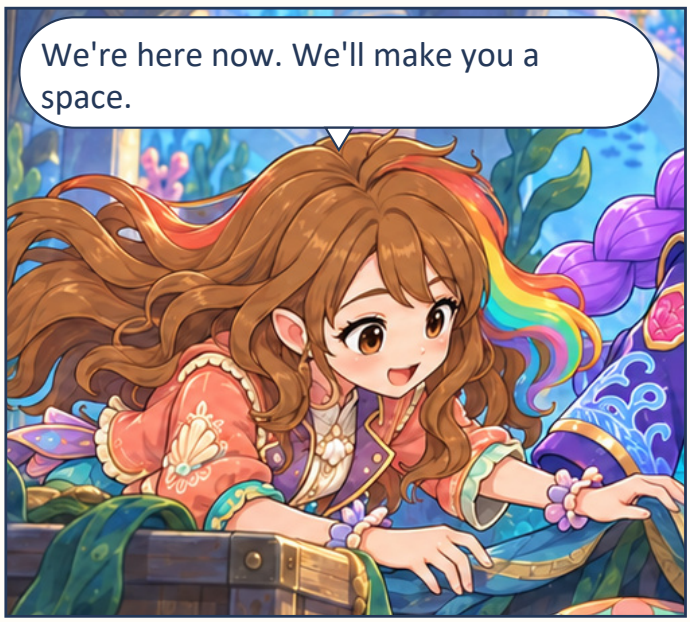
The tapping is behind those fronds.


Hana waited for the little sound.

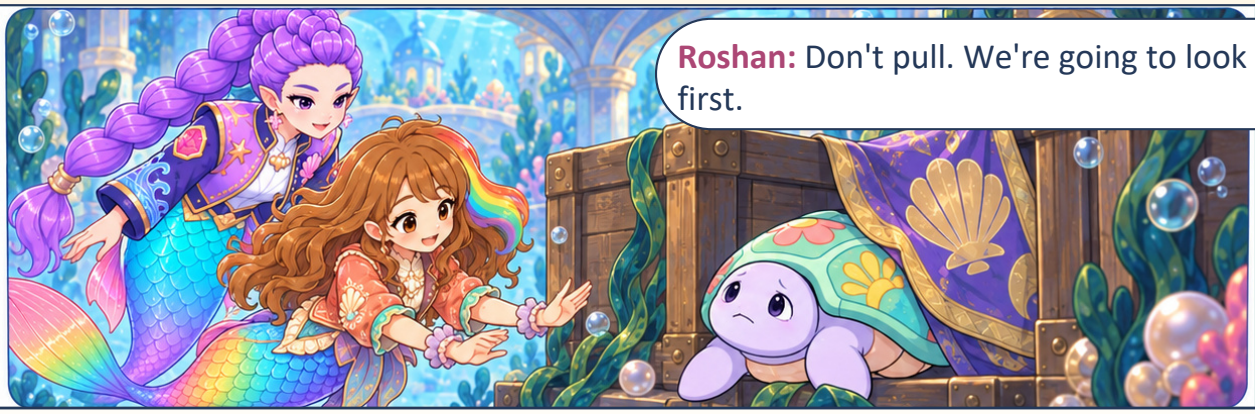
Rumi held the soft kelp aside. Roshan swam through the clear space. A warm lantern shone ahead.


Two concert crates pressed close together. Duri was caught between them, with a soft banner snagged at his shell.

The crates blocked my delivery. I tried to move them. Then they slid.


We're here now. We'll make you a space.

Roshan floated beside Duri. His tapping had become very quiet.



Hana began to push a crate. The cloth tugged. Everyone stopped.

Roshan: Then I'll move the crate.

Hana: Tell me when. I'll hold the other one.

Rumi slipped the cloth over Duri's shell. Roshan braced both hands on the crate.
Nari: One. Two. Gently.

Roshan pushed sideways. Hana steadied the other crate. A little space opened.
Roshan: Can you move your flippers?

One flipper. Two flippers. Duri paddled free and touched Roshan's hand.

You heard me!

You kept tapping.

Rumi caught his drifting courier basket. The bells were safe, and so was Duri.

Rumi: No more carrying that alone today.

Nari tapped the crate. Duri tapped back. Tap. Tap. Tap.

Hana: Now let's find you somewhere cozy.

The warm-current bathhouse was quiet. The friends could finally rest.

Duri: I kept tapping. But everything was so loud.

Roshan: My voice feels little too.

Hana: Are we singers or sea bunnies?

Nari's towel had funny ears. Duri untucked his flippers. Roshan laughed beside him.

They settled on a cream couch. Hana spread out her long fin.

I dance BIG. I rest BIG too.

Nari: Room for one small turtle, please.

Hana folded her fin. Duri nestled between them.

Roshan: Make a space and let it through. There's a place for me and you.

They hummed softly and shared seaweed snacks.

A top hat bobbed through the curtain. POOF! Rumi drew Duri close.

Nari: That wasn't our song.

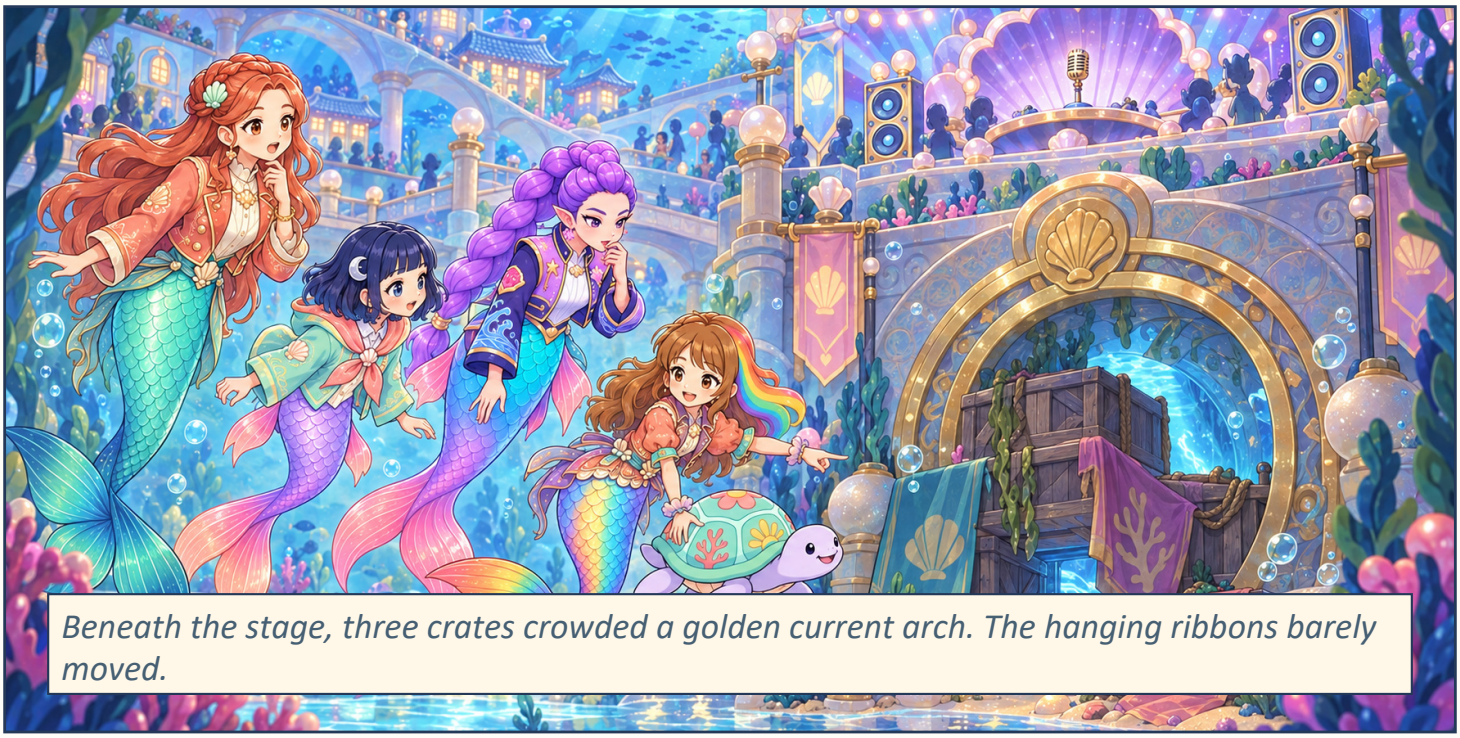
Our enormous show! Only our voices!

The performer imp flourished a sparkling banner. Duri paddled up.

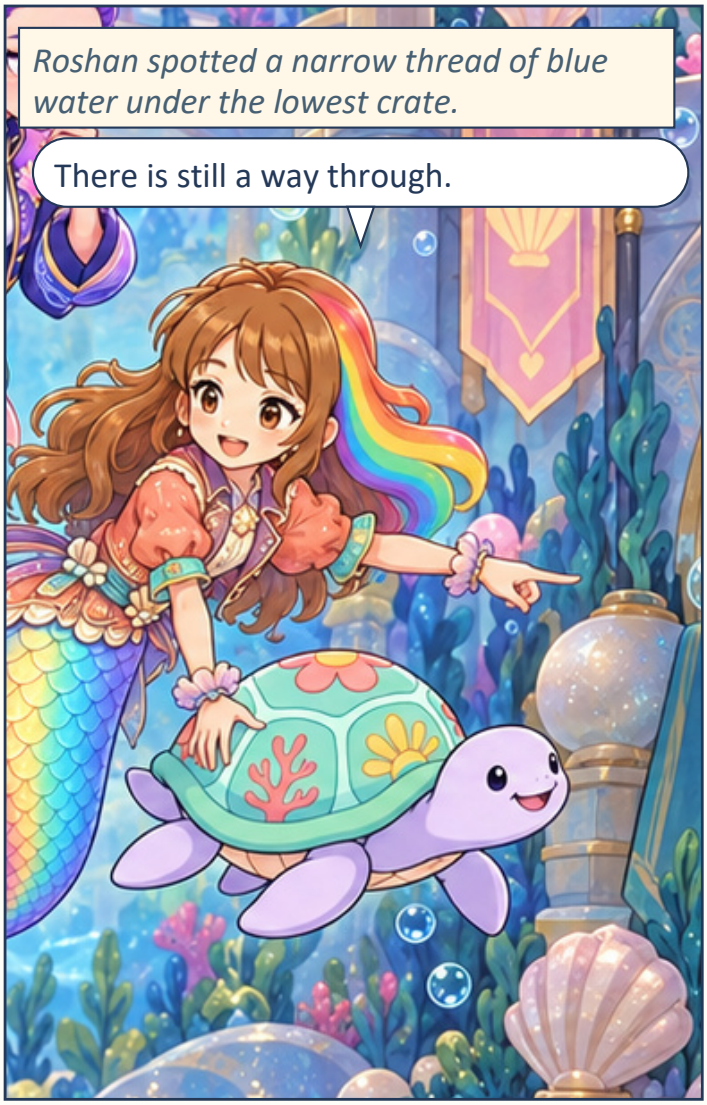
Your show crates blocked my delivery.

Roshan: Let's see where they put them.

The imps hurried towards the stage. The friends followed.

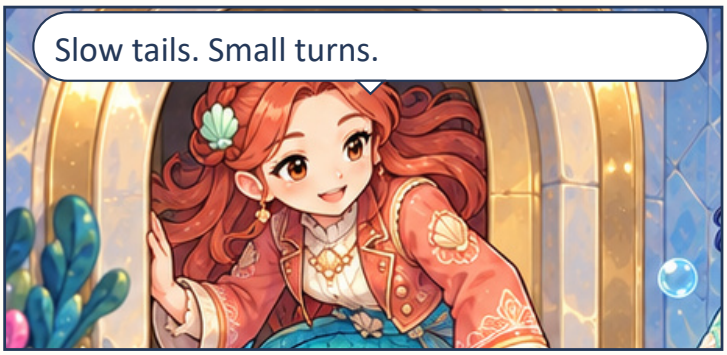

Beneath the stage, three crates crowded a golden current arch. The hanging ribbons barely moved.

Rumi: The magic is here. But the song can't travel through.


Roshan spotted a narrow thread of blue water under the lowest crate.
There is still a way through.

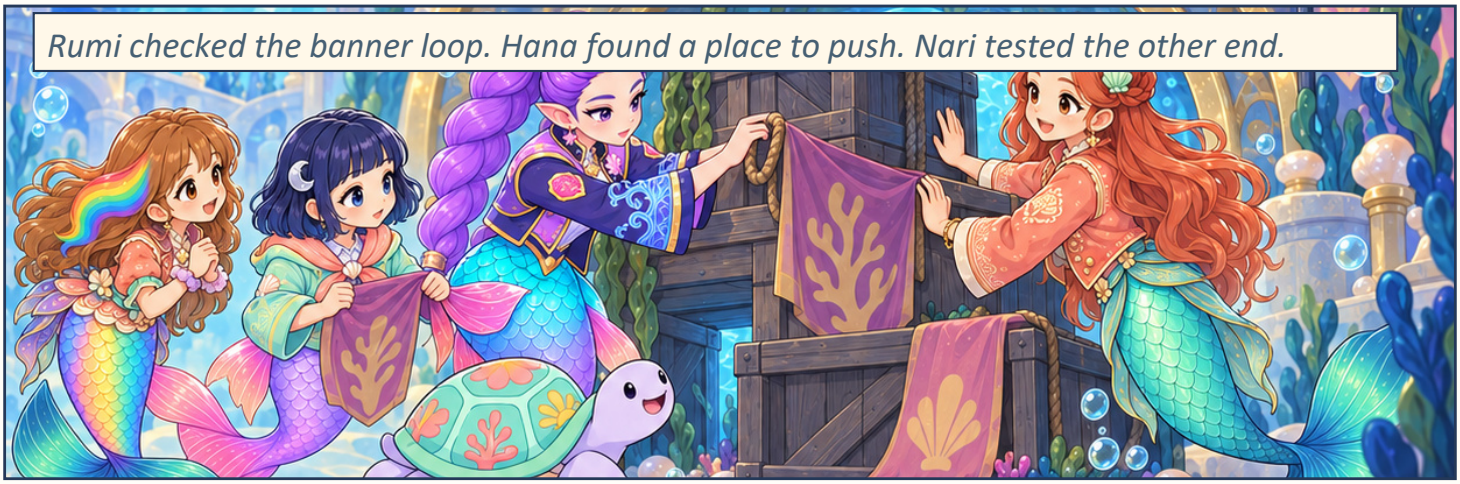
I deliver parcels here. I know a way in.
He led them behind the bridge.

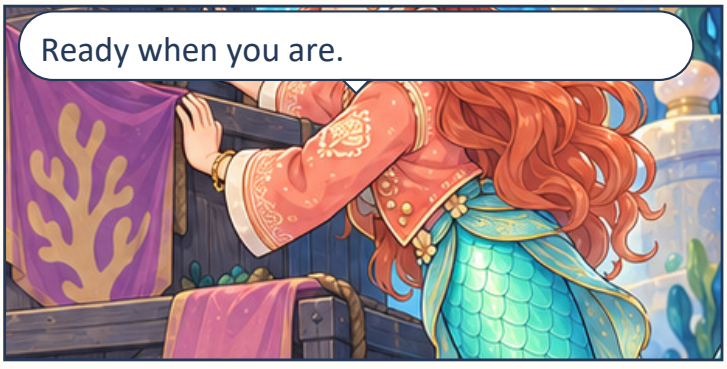
Hana folded her big fin close and took her time.

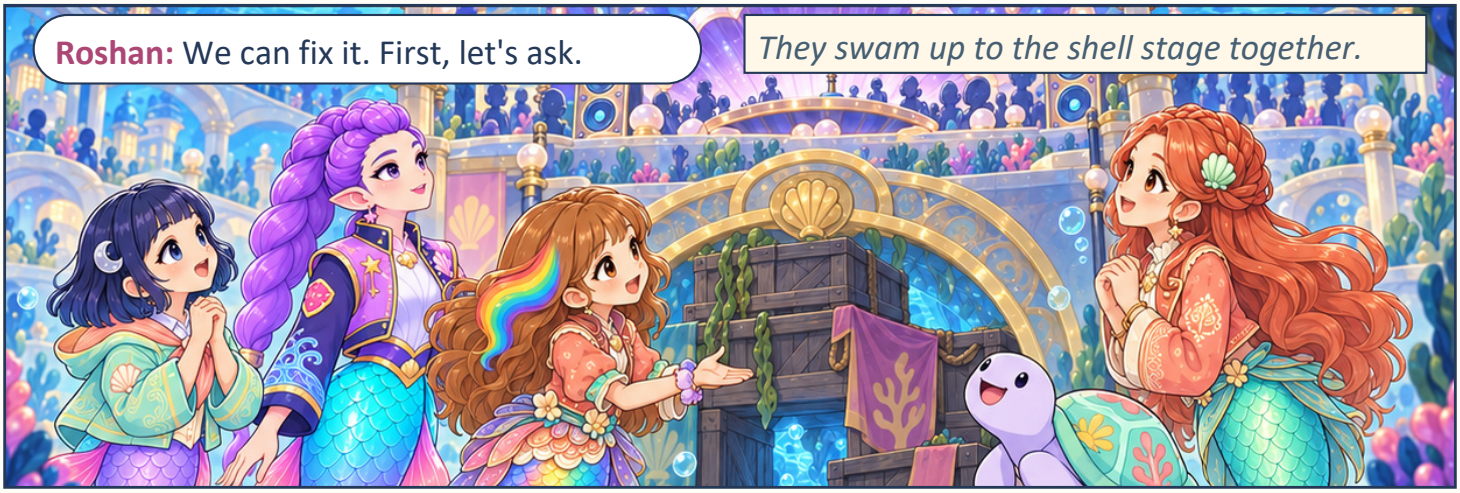

Slow tails. Small turns.

Nari listened at each turn. This time she spoke clearly.
Nari: Left here!
Roshan followed. Little things made a useful path.

That crate can slide sideways.
There's a clear ledge for the props. I use it for parcels.


Rumi checked the banner loop. Hana found a place to push. Nari tested the other end.


Ready when you are.


Roshan: We can fix it. First, let's ask.
They swam up to the shell stage together.

Roshan: Your crates trapped Duri. And they're blocking the city's song. Will you move them?

Performer Imp: Our show needs enormous props!

He puffed out his glittery jacket.

The farthest terraces stayed quiet.

Rumi: It needs neighbours too. There's room for your show and everyone else's voices.

Roshan: We'll put the scenery safely at the side.

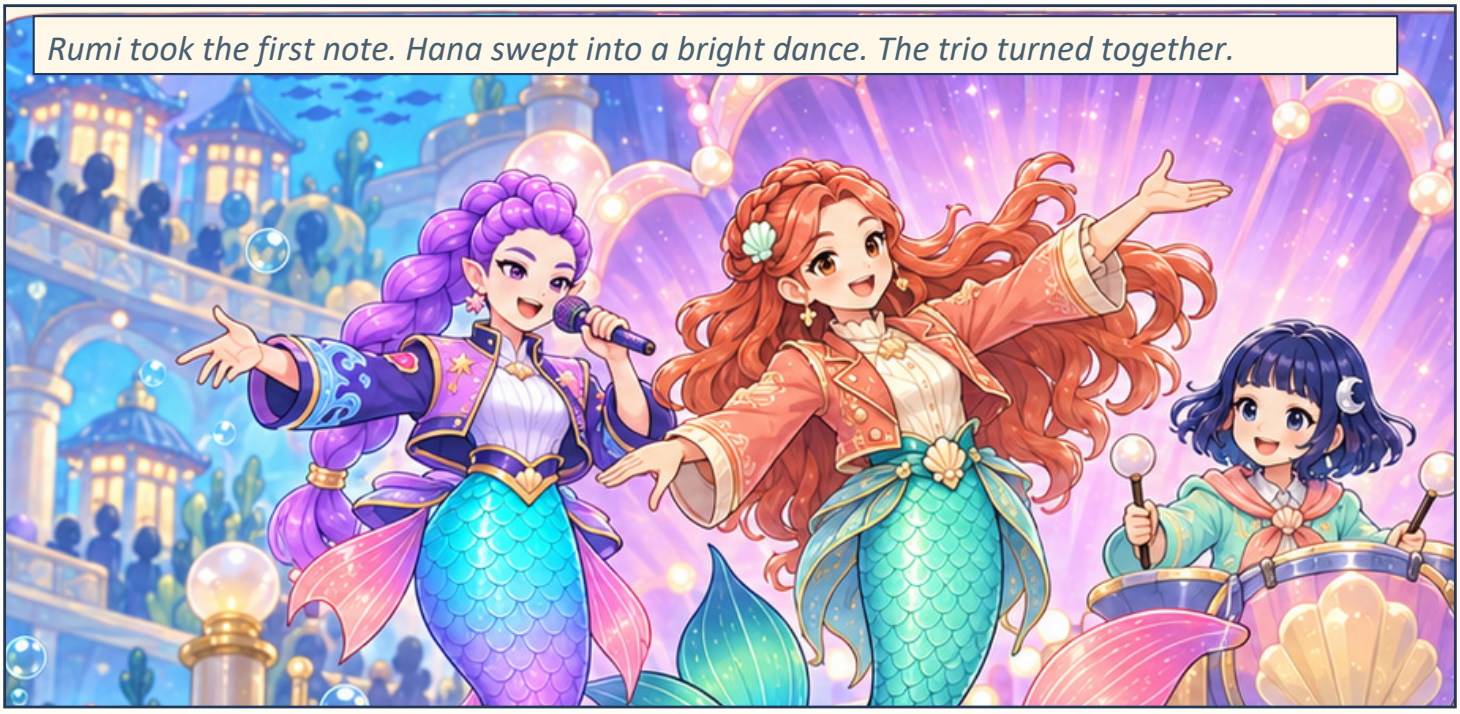
Magician Imp: Nobody touches our spectacular scenery!

POOF! Bubbles poured between Roshan and the gate. She paused instead of pushing through.

The performer lifted a soft foam star. Hana caught a corner of the banner.

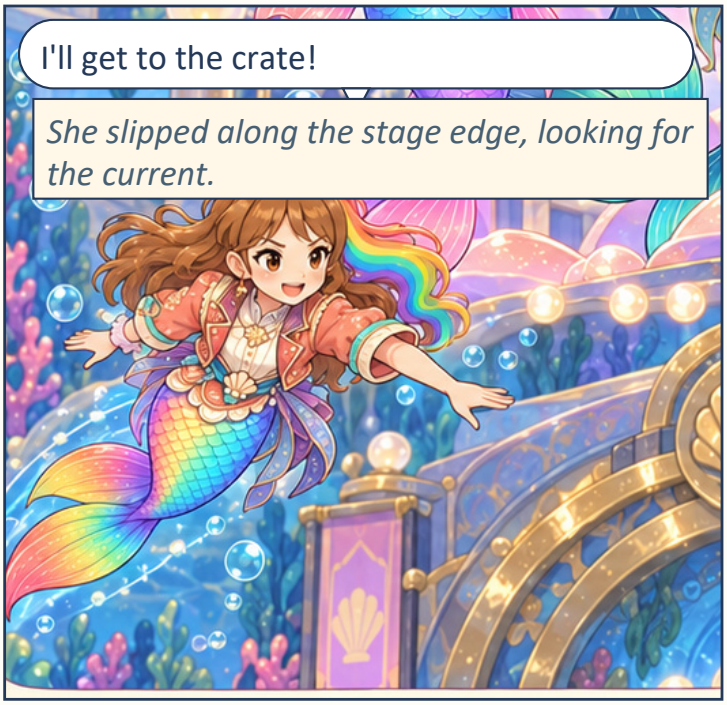
Hana: Now we need our big moves.

Rumi took the first note. Hana swept into a bright dance. The trio turned together.



I'll get to the crate!

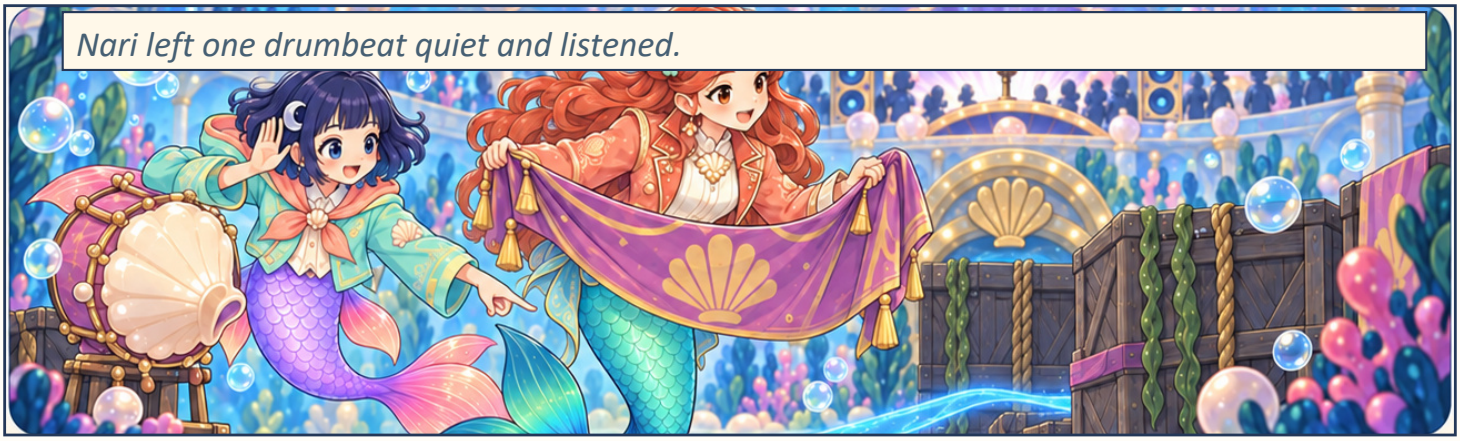
She slipped along the stage edge, looking for the current.

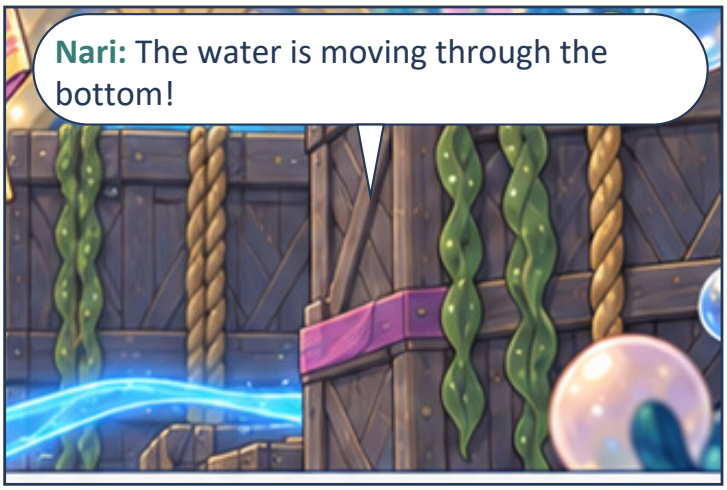


Nari tapped the shell drum.

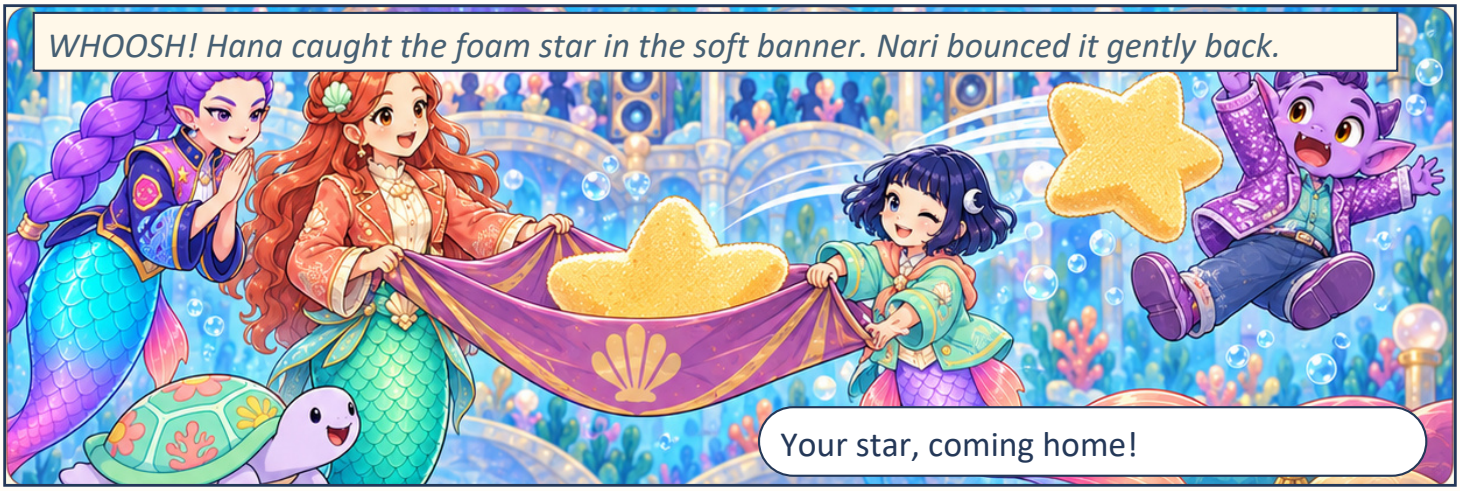
Keep the beat with me. We'll keep the way clear!

The bubble cloud hid the gate. Roshan stopped and watched the little blue thread of water.


Nari left one drumbeat quiet and listened.


Nari: The water is moving through the bottom!

Roshan ducked beneath the bubbles. Above her, Rumi spun clear of another puff.
Rumi: Little voice, big blue sea!

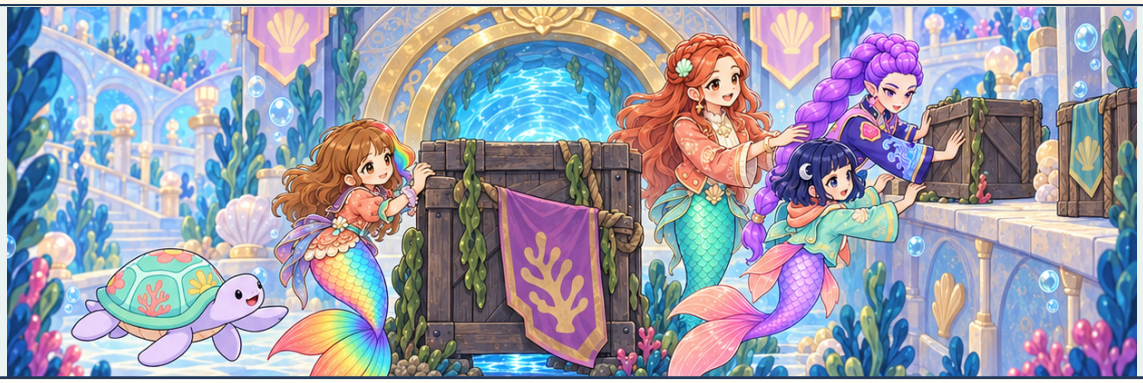

WHOOSH! Hana caught the foam star in the soft banner. Nari bounced it gently back.
Your star, coming home!

The performer tumbled onto his padded cushions.

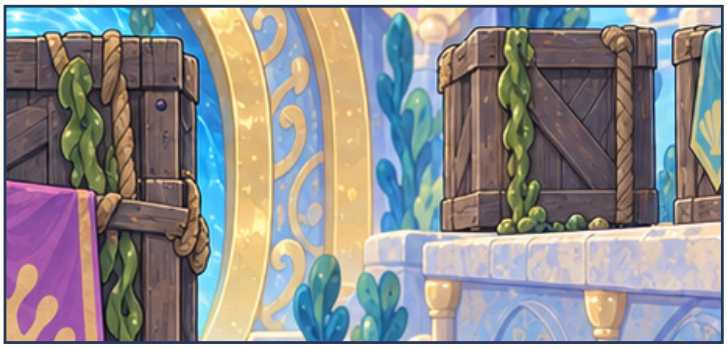
Oof! A very soft landing!

The magician's next puff spun his hat backwards. BUMP! He landed beside his friend.
Hana: Big moves. Soft finish.

Rumi and Nari slid the two small crates onto the side ledge. Hana steadied them. One large crate remained.



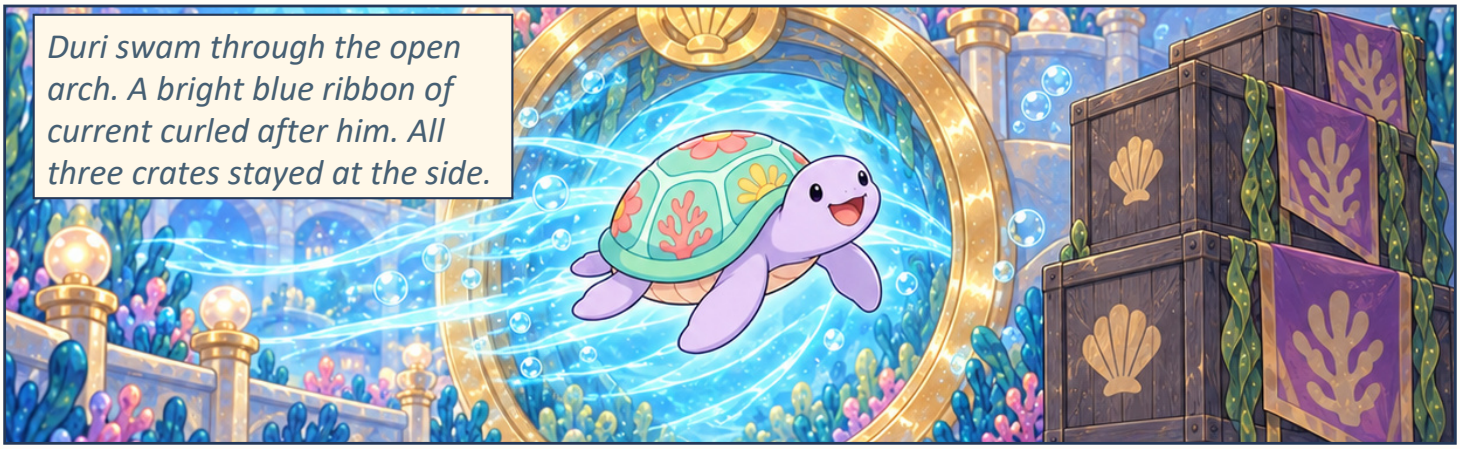
Roshan looped the banner through its handle. She pulled. The crate moved a little, then stopped.



Roshan: I need you!

Duri checked the clear space. Her friends came to take their places.

Hana, push. Rumi, with me. Nari, count.
One. Two. Gently!
The last crate slid clear.


Duri swam through the open arch. A bright blue ribbon of current curled after him. All three crates stayed at the side.

There!
The ribbons stirred above the stage. The magic had been there all along.

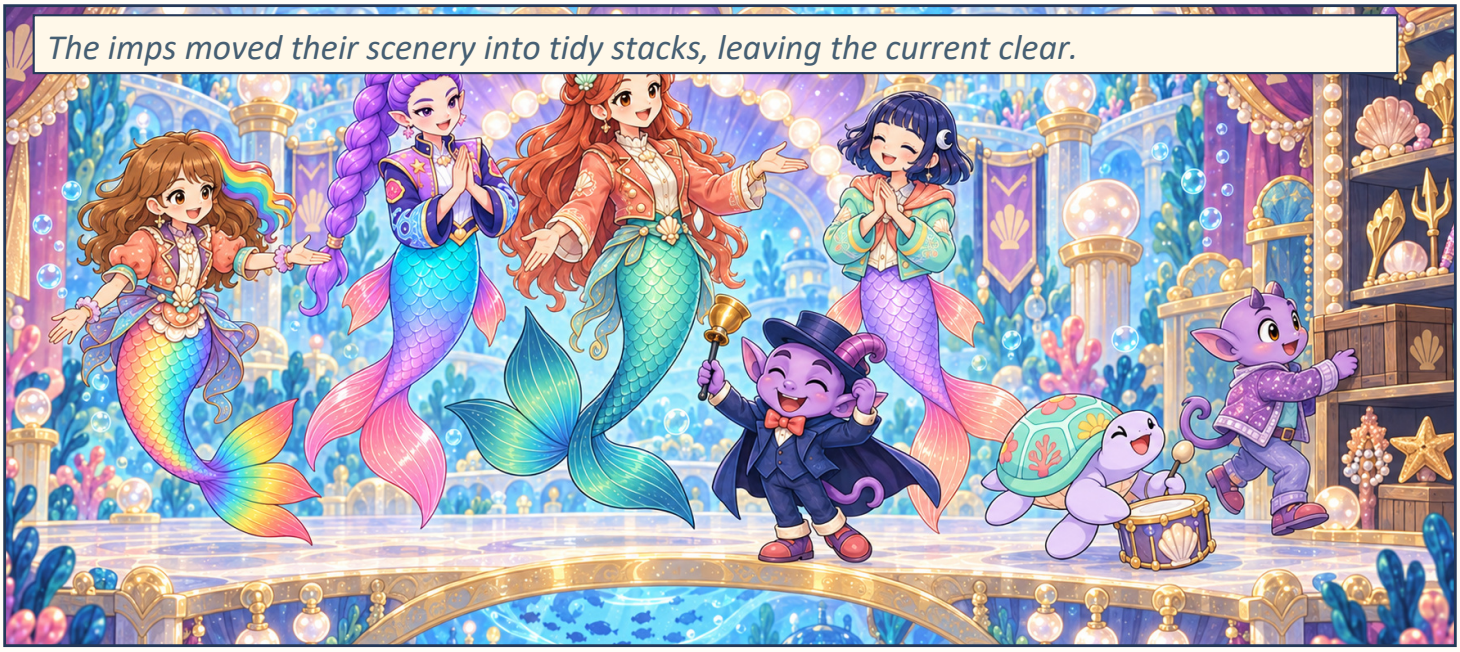
The current reached the shops. Duri tapped at a window. One little voice answered. Then another.

He hurried past the bathhouse. Its neighbours hummed the familiar tune. The bridge ribbons fluttered.

At the tram, more voices joined in. Duri's delivery was a song this time.

Duri: Everyone, there's room for you!

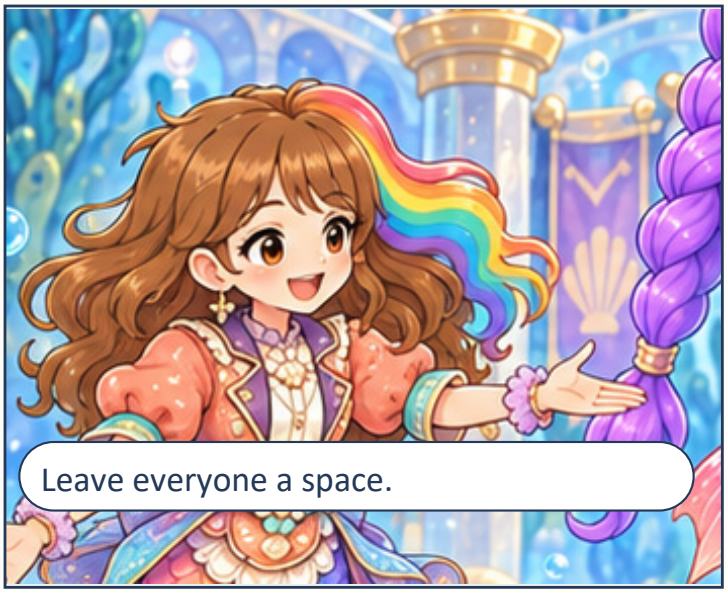
The imps moved their scenery into tidy stacks, leaving the current clear.



Nobody sang with our show.

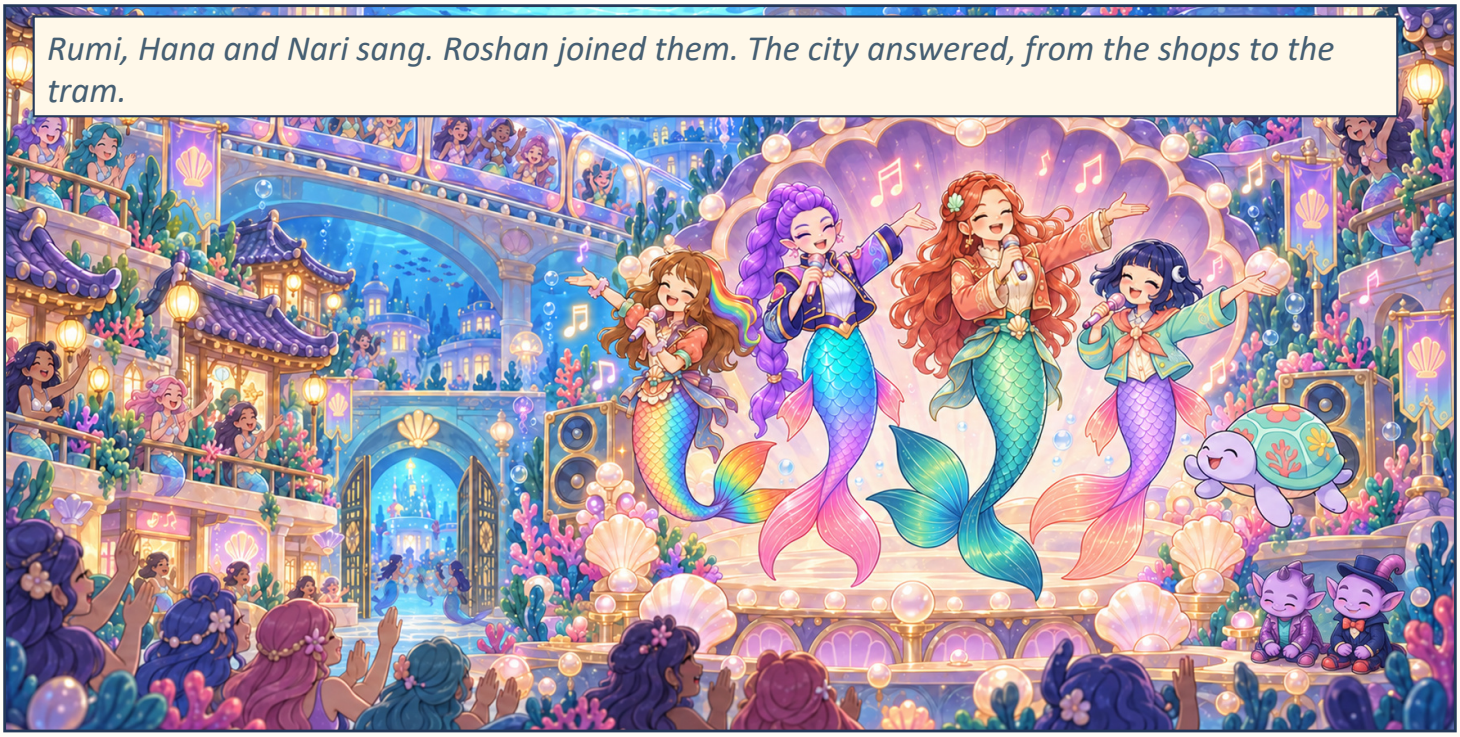
You blocked their song.

We didn't mean to trap you, Duri. Can we help now?



Leave everyone a space.

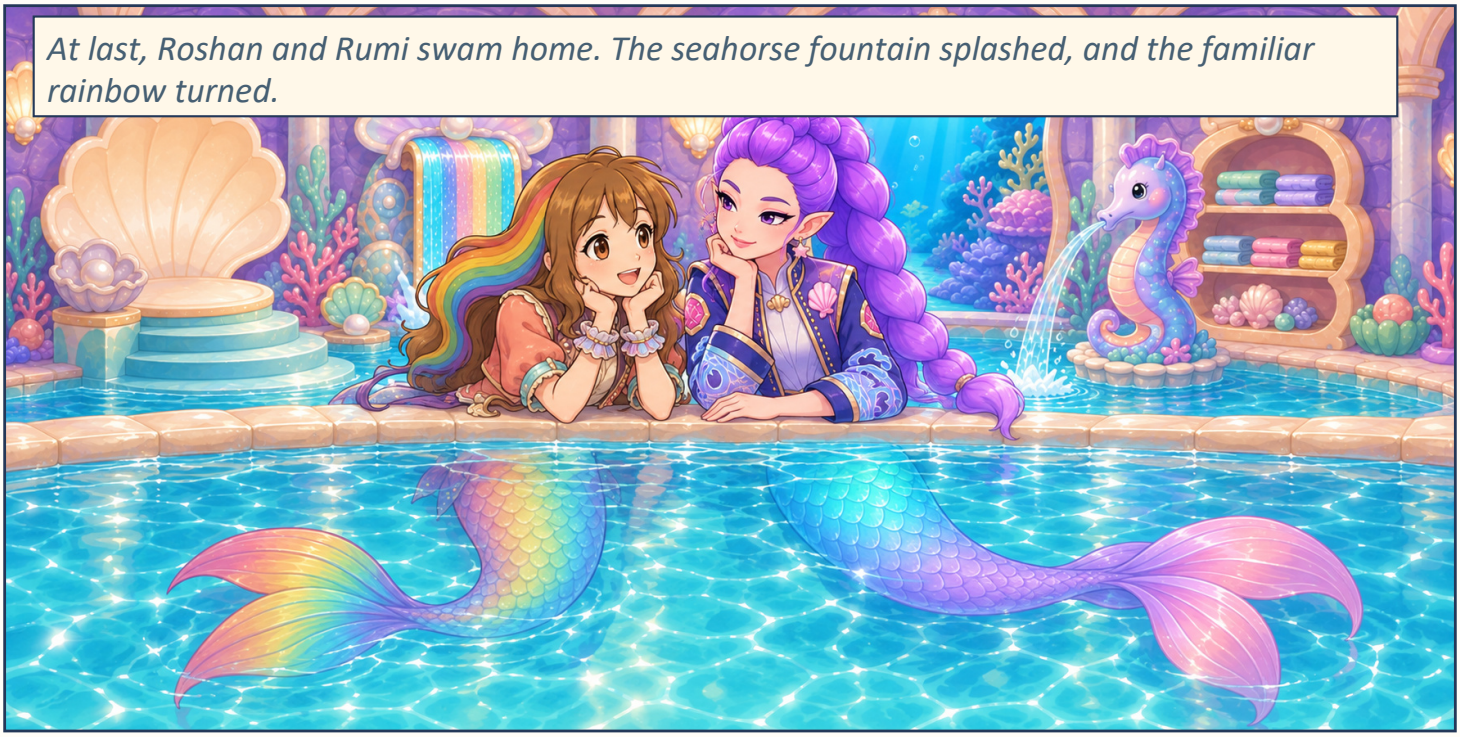
Rumi, Hana and Nari sang. Roshan joined them. The city answered, from the shops to the tram.



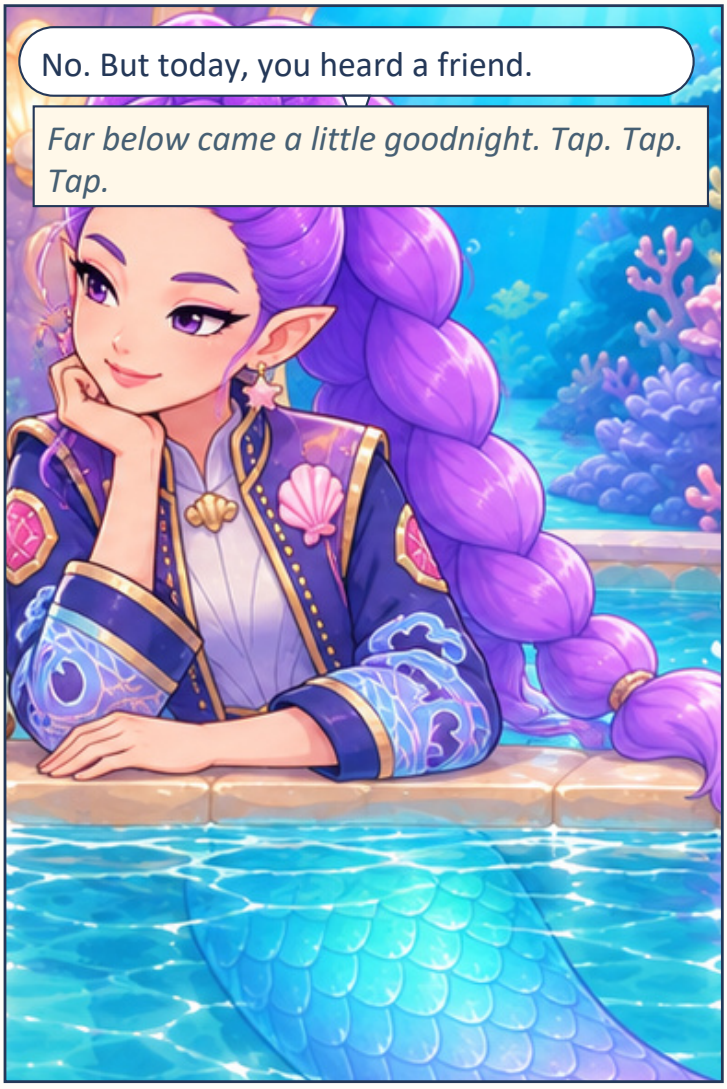
Little voice, big blue sea.
Sing with you, sing with me.

Make a space and let it through.
There's a place for me and you.

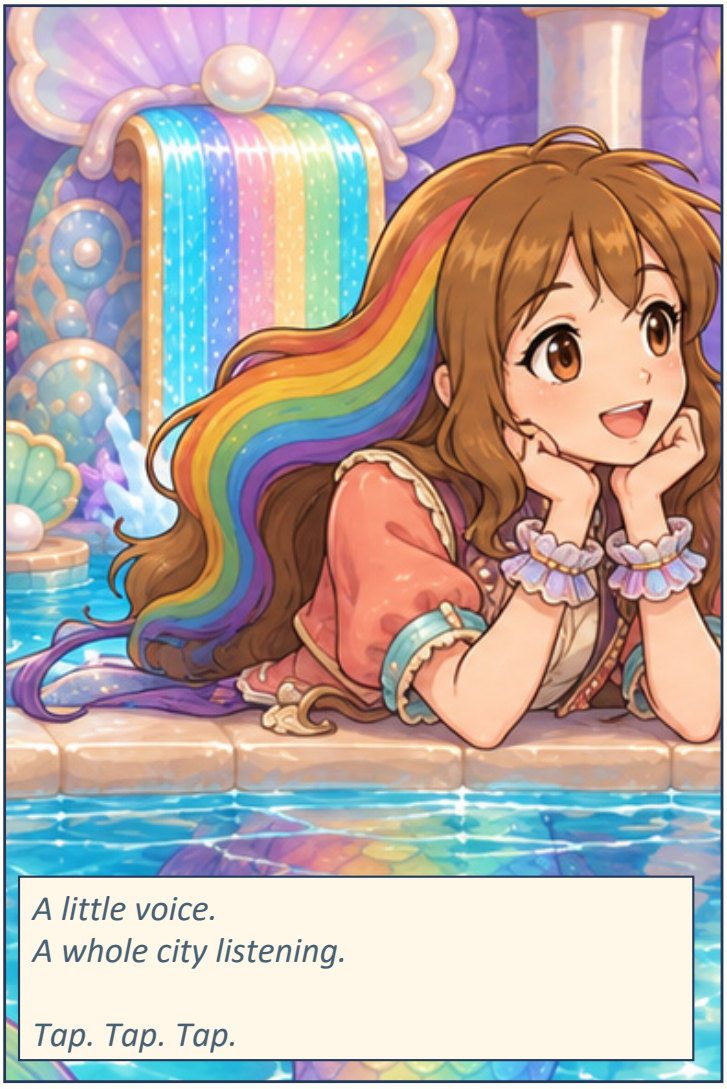
Roshan heard every voice.


At last, Roshan and Rumi swam home. The seahorse fountain splashed, and the familiar rainbow turned.

We haven't found the candle yet.


No. But today, you heard a friend.
Far below came a little goodnight. Tap. Tap. Tap.

Roshan
Rumi
Hana
Nari
Duri


A little voice.
A whole city listening.
Tap. Tap. Tap.